



SUNDAY SCHOOL SIMPLIFIED

BEYOND BUMPER STICKERS

— SCRIPTURE THAT STICKS —

Vol. 01
A SIX LESSON PACKET

A LETTER FROM THE CANDLER FOUNDRY

Dear Friend,

Maybe you've noticed — as we have — that some of the Bible's most beloved lines have become a little too familiar.

"I know the plans I have for you."

"Be still, and know that I am God."

"I can do all things through him who strengthens me."

We've posted them on billboards, stitched them onto pillows, and, yes, printed them on bumper stickers. While these soundbites often provide comfort, there's plenty to explore beneath the surface.

Beyond Bumper Stickers is an invitation to slow down and read six of these well-worn passages in their original historical context. In doing so, we hope you'll find each verse to be more spiritually enriching than ever before.

We've designed these lessons to be easy — you can study on your own or with a group, no leader necessary.

We're glad you're here. May these old, familiar words meet you in a new way.

Grace and peace,

THE CANDLER FOUNDRY

IN THIS PACKET

1 For I Know the Plans I Have for You

JEREMIAH 29

2 Be Still, and Know That I Am God

PSALM 46

3 Have Dominion Over the Earth

GENESIS 1-2

4 I Can Do All Things Through Him

PHILIPPIANS 4

5 All Scripture Is Inspired by God

2 TIMOTHY 3

6 Love Is Patient, Love Is Kind

1 CORINTHIANS 13

THE RHYTHM OF EACH LESSON

1

Open with prayer.

2

Read the passage out loud as a group.

3

Watch the provided 3-Minute Bible video.

4

Talk through the questions.

5

Close with prayer.



FOR I KNOW THE PLANS I HAVE FOR YOU

Jeremiah 29:1, 4-14



OPENING PRAYER

Faithful God, you spoke hope to your people even in the long years of exile. As we open these familiar words together, free us from easy slogans and lead us into the fuller story you are telling. Give us patience to listen, honesty to question, and trust to hope. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Jeremiah 29:1, 4–14

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Jeremiah's Letter to the Exiles

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ① "For I know the plans I have for you..." (v. 11) is the line we meet on mugs and graduation cards. Often, we interpret this verse as a promise to an individual person. Who is the "you" that is being addressed in this passage? Does this change your original perception of verse 11?
- ② God promises a return to Jerusalem. Will the exiles who received the letter participate in the return? How might Jeremiah's exiled audience have received this message?
- ③ In verses 4-7, what sort of life are the exiles instructed to lead until the promise is fulfilled? When God speaks in verse 11 of "plans for welfare and not for harm," what does "welfare" seem to mean?
- ④ A popular translation of v. 11 reads "plans to prosper you" (NIV). How is "prosperity" commonly understood today? How does "prosper" in place of "welfare" change the meaning — and is God promising prosperity the way we tend to imagine it?
- ⑤ The exiles were asked to settle in, seek the good of Babylon, and keep their faith in a hopeful future. Where have you had to remain faithful amid disappointing or uncertain circumstances in your own life?



CLOSING PRAYER

God of exiles and of homecomings, thank you for promises bigger than our slogans. As we go, plant us where you have placed us, teach us to seek the good of our neighbors, and keep us hopeful through the long seasons of waiting. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



BE STILL AND KNOW THAT I AM GOD

Psalm 46



OPENING PRAYER

God our refuge and strength, when the earth feels unsteady and the nations rage, you remain a very present help. Quiet the noise within us as we gather, and teach us a stillness that is not escape but trust. Help us hear your voice above the roar. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Psalm 46

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

God Is Our Refuge: Reading Psalm 46

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 "Be still, and know that I am God" is often taken as a cue to slow down. Where have you heard this verse, and what have you taken it to mean?
- 2 The video argues we often read the Psalms too "spiritually," when many reflect material, outward catastrophes — war, displacement, upheaval. What words or phrases in Psalm 46 point to that kind of suffering?
- 3 God is "a very present help in trouble" (v. 1) — help in the trouble, even as the mountains shake. The psalm does promise deliverance (v. 9), but that day hasn't come. What refuge is God offering in the meantime, and what does it ask of us while we wait?
- 4 Verse 10's command to "be still" could also be translated as "stop fighting" or "let go." Given the raging nations, who might God be telling to be still — anxious individuals, or the warring powers? How does that change what the verse asks of us?
- 5 "Be still and know" is often handed out as a call to relax. After sitting with the whole psalm, what would it mean to "be still" in an upheaval you can't control — not as escape, but as trust that God, not the chaos, is in charge? How is being still as trust different from being still as feeling calm?



CLOSING PRAYER

Lord of hosts, you are with us; God of Jacob, you are our refuge. Send us out steadier than we came — not because the waters have calmed, but because we know who holds us in them. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



HAVE DOMINION OVER THE EARTH

Genesis 1:26-31;
2:15



OPENING PRAYER

Creator God, you spoke the world into being and called it good, and you entrusted its care to creatures made in your image. As we open these first pages of Scripture, free us from the habit of reading them as permission, and teach us to read them as calling. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Genesis 1:26–31; 2:15

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Image & Dominion: Reading Genesis 1–2

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 Genesis 1:26 is an oft-quoted text. Where have you heard it alluded to, and in what context?
- 2 Before humans are told what to do, they're told who they are — made “in the image of God” (1:26–27). What identity does that give us, and why might identity come before instruction?
- 3 Outside the Bible, “dominion” usually means control or domination. But in Genesis this dominion is over a world God has already made and repeatedly called “good.” How should that reframe what “dominion” is meant to look like?
- 4 The video notes Genesis tells two creation stories. In the second (2:5–15), God forms the human from the dust and places them “to till and keep” the garden — and “till” can also mean “to serve.” How does that picture of serving the ground reshape “dominion” — is service in tension with it, or its true form?
- 5 If both dominion and service are part of our calling, where do you see them in tension in your own life? Can we serve creation while also exercising real power over it?



CLOSING PRAYER

God of the garden, you placed us here to till and to keep. Make us faithful image-bearers — gentle with what you have made, mindful of those who come after us, and grateful for the good earth you still call good. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



I CAN DO ALL THINGS THROUGH CHRIST

Philippians 2:2-11;
4:10-13



OPENING PRAYER

Generous God, you meet us in plenty and in want, and your strength is made perfect in our weakness. As we open Paul's letter written from prison, teach us the contentment he learned, and loosen our grip on the slogans we mistake for faith. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Philippians 2:2–11; 4:10–13

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Content in All Things: Paul from Prison

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ① Philippians 4:13 is often used on posters, in sports, or as a motivational phrase. Where have you seen or heard it used, and what message do you think it usually conveys?
- ② In our culture, when we describe someone as "strong" (whether it's a political leader, an athlete, or a business leader) what do we usually mean? What does strength look like in those settings?
- ③ In Philippians 2:2–11, we hear the Christ hymn, where Jesus empties himself, takes the form of a servant, and becomes obedient even to death on a cross. In light of that passage, how does our usual understanding of strength get challenged? How does Jesus demonstrate strength?
- ④ In Philippians 4:11–12, Paul describes being in need, experiencing hunger, and living through changing circumstances. What do these details suggest about Paul's situation when he writes this?
- ⑤ When Paul says, "I can do all things through him who strengthens me," do you think he is talking about overcoming weakness, or something else? What in the passage leads you to that conclusion?
- ⑥ If strength looks less like control or success and more like faithfulness within difficult circumstances, how might that change the way we think about what it means to be strong in our own lives?



CLOSING PRAYER

Christ Jesus, you emptied yourself for our sake; give us strength that looks like yours — patient, humble, and shared. When we have little and when we have much, keep us content in you, and grateful for the people who carry us. In your name we pray. Amen.



ALL SCRIPTURE IS INSPIRED BY GOD

2 Timothy 3:14-17;
Genesis 2: 4-7



OPENING PRAYER

Living God, you breathed life into dust and called it holy, and you breathe through Scripture to speak to us still. As we open your word, give us reverence without fear and honesty without pride. Teach us to receive what is holy and to discern it with care. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 3:14–17; Genesis 2:4–7

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Inspired by God (2 Timothy 3:16)

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 To the extent you were raised in a church tradition, what did that tradition teach about the Bible and its authority? How did you engage with Scripture in your early formative years?
- 2 How does your current church community read, teach, and interpret Scripture? Has your relationship to Scripture changed over time? How important is Scripture to your faith today?
- 3 As the video explains, the Greek word translated "inspired" in 2 Timothy 3:16 literally means "God-breathed." In Genesis, God's breath gives life to humans. Is it difficult to hold both that a creation can be from God and that the same creation is subject to human limitation? Why or why not?
- 4 In 2 Timothy, Scripture is described as something that teaches, corrects, and trains over time. What does that mean in practice for your community? What guardrails does your tradition use to avoid interpretations that are self-serving, unloving, or unfaithful?
- 5 Which understanding of Scripture asks more of us — that the Bible is factually inerrant, or one that allows for human error and requires us to discern its meaning? (No wrong answer.)
- 6 Have you ever found a Biblical text life-giving and meaningful even if you didn't read it as factually true? Have you found "good news" in a passage that first felt confusing or troubling? What helped that shift?



CLOSING PRAYER

Faithful God, thank you for a word both holy and human — inspired by your breath and carried in earthen vessels. Keep us humble as we read, generous as we discern, and open to how your Spirit teaches, corrects, and trains us still. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



LOVE IS PATIENT, LOVE IS KIND

1 Corinthians 13:1-13



OPENING PRAYER

God who is love, you have poured your love into our hearts and called us to live it among people we do not always find easy. As we open this familiar chapter, save us from hearing only a wedding poem, and let it search us as the challenge Paul meant it to be. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

1 Corinthians 13:1–13

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition

[Read online at Bible Gateway \(NRSVUE\)](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

More Than a Wedding Poem: 1 Corinthians 13

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ① “Love is patient, love is kind” is a wedding staple. But the video notes Paul wrote this to a church in conflict. What words or phrases in the text hint at that setting? Does knowing he was writing to a troubled congregation change how you read it?
- ② What words or phrases best describe Paul’s understanding of love here? How is it similar to the ways you show love in your own life — and how is it different?
- ③ Paul writes to a congregation fighting about spiritual gifts like prophecy and speaking in tongues. If he were writing verses 1–3 for the church today, what ministries, gifts, or achievements might he name — the things we’re tempted to prize?
- ④ Churches often measure success by growth — programs, membership, attendance. How does Paul’s understanding of love challenge those measures? How would Paul define a church’s success or failure?
- ⑤ Consider your own church’s worship and common life. Where do you see Paul’s vision of love lived out well, and where is there room to grow — especially across a congregation’s diverse opinions and backgrounds?



CLOSING PRAYER

Patient and kind God, make your love visible in this community — slow to anger, quick to bear, ready to hope. Let us treasure love above every gift, for love alone never ends. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Optional viewing for classes that want to go deeper — each is a short 3-Minute Bible video.

What Happened During the Exile?

Lesson 1 · Jeremiah 29 · 3-Minute Bible · optional
Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



*Sunday School Simplified is a project of The Candler Foundry,
making the best of biblical scholarship accessible to
everyone.*

CANDLERFOUNDRY.EMORY.EDU